

able to witness. What this means is up to you, but some examples are provided:

- **Poison:** If Verik was able to poison the water, assume that in addition to any adventurers affected, all the unnamed villagers and the crones are poisoned (disadvantage on ability checks and speed halved).
- **Traps:** Verik disables any traps he can, whether by triggering them from a distance or by tying a fluttering red cloth over them to make the obvious.
- **Wall:** If the adventurers made a low wall or a ditch, Verik moves the rear, away from the main fighting and lays planks over them to make it easy for the secondary group to scale them quickly.
- **Assassinate:** If the Verik is still loose in the village and the melee is in full progress, he may join the battle, striking when an adventurer or allied NPC is alone or vulnerable.

DEVELOPMENTS

If captured, the kobolds and sailors break easily. They readily admit they are here at the command of the Cult of the Dragon cultist Ixas who is just off the shore of the island awaiting their return. There were to gather up all the books and potentially magical items and burn the rest. All captives were to be brought in their longboats back to the ship for Ixas to interrogate with a magical statue that he has in quarters. The statue of the dracolich probes the mind of the victim, forcing them to answer all questions put to them, but it is a horrible process that damages the mind and steals one's sanity.

Assuming the adventurers are successful, the villagers encourage them to take the battle to the ship, but they do not join them. They want all the "Outsides" off their island. Only Elisande is willing to go with them.

If the adventurers are defeated and captured, they are tied up while kobolds search the village. Elisande sneaks into the group of them with a knife and pretends to be tied up, but as soon as the adventurers are piled into the longboats with their weapons in a pile on the floor, she has an opportunity and she starts cutting the adventurers free.

PART 5: HIGH SEAS

The adventure culminates as the adventurers climb over the side of the Cult of the Dragon's ship and face the mastermind behind this foul plot.

TAKING THE FIGHT TO THE SHIP

The adventurers should realize that the attackers came from off shore, and by heading down to the landing, they find two longboats beached with oars at the ready. The characters can take the longboats out into the mist-filled water and look for Ixas' ship.

Each longboat can hold eight characters, six if they have lots of gear.

THE RETURN OF THE AUDACITY

After the characters have been rowing for about twenty minutes, they come upon Ixas' vessel, and witness the return of the *Audacity*.

Suddenly the sea quiets, the mysterious fog lifts from the water and the storm abates. For a brief moment you see the sky clearly, the sliver of Selune shining down upon you.

Looming in front of you is the ship you've been searching for!

Just then, your longboat takes on a red cast, like the baleful eye of some great reptile. A terrible tearing sound is heard, followed by a great rushing of wind and heat. Angry screams erupt. The fog returns, billowing from the ship ahead. As you bring the longboat close in to the ship's ladder on the port side, screams of fear and pain emanate from the deck above.

The adventurers have just witnessed the arrival of the *Audacity* returning from the Nine Hells as the adventurers broke the pact between the Folk and Tiamat's followers (by either opening the scroll on the altar, taking wealth from the village, taking Elisande with them, killing the lemure or discovering the secret of the pact). At the start of the fight, the *Audacity* is blocked from view by the Cult's ship.

Once the adventurers climb the ladder up to Ixas' ship, they see the returned vessel as well as carnage breaking out between Ixas' group and the infernal pirates.

As you top the ladder, you see a glowing ship made of bones and issuing a baleful fog, its bowsprit tangled in the rigging of the forecastle of the ship you sought. The crews of each ship are already in battle with one another. The kobolds and sailors disguised as undead battle another crew—a group of red-skinned humans dressed as buccaneers. The ship, missing one of its two long boats, has the name *Audacity* lettered across the side. Both ships are on fire.

The cult of the dragon's force include **Ixas (I)**, two **human guards (G)**, and six **kobolds (K)**. The crew of the *Audacity* includes **Captain Reeve Sar Testain (C)** and five infernal-tainted **pirates (P)**. At the beginning of the combat, the two crews are fighting each other and neither is paying much attention to the adventurers. However, the adventurers should not assume that anyone is their ally. Both plan to kill the adventurers as soon as they deal with their more immediate threat. Each side always engages the nearest foe unless someone specifically antagonizes them (such as a caster or archer attacking them from a distance).

Do not roll for each of the enemies who are fighting each other. Rather, speed things up using this abstraction. At the end of every round, count the number of enemies on each side (Cult or Pirate) not engaged with an adventurer and add that number to a d20 roll. The side with the higher total kills one enemy on the losing side. This roll can never result in the NPCs killing **Ixas** or **Captain Reeve Sar Testain**. They remain entirely for the adventurers to deal with.

When combat begins, Ixas has already expended one of his 2nd-level spell slots.

INFERNAL PIRATES

While the infernal pirates (use the **bandit** statistics, but they are worth 50 XP each) are human, their sixty-year-long imprisonment in the Nine Hells has bestowed upon them immunities similar to those of their fiendish tormentors. Captain Testain and his infernal crew have the following infernal boons.

- Resistance to cold damage.
- Resistance to bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing damage from nonmagical weapons that are not silvered.
- Immunity to fire and poison.
- Advantage on any saving throw made to resist the *frightened* condition.

The infernal tainted pirates bear the scars of their torturous imprisonment at the hand of Tiamat; each is disfigured with various scars and marks.

- The flesh of one of the pirates' arms is blackened as if by exposure to intense cold or frostbite.
- Another pirate bears the tell-tale marks of lightning damage. He smells faintly of ozone.
- The leg of a third pirate is charred all the way to the bone.
- One of the arms of the fourth pirate has been completely melted away.
- The face and arm of a fifth pirate bears a number of greenish pustules that weep a sickly yellow fluid.

GENERAL FEATURES

The fight takes place onboard the Cult's ship with the *Audacity* having struck it perpendicular and become tangled up in her rigging.

Light. The cult's ship glows with an unearthly white radiance that provides bright light. In addition where the two ships are in contact, there is a fire.

Fire. Fire fills the squares where the ships have come into contact with one another. This fire spreads at the rate of 1 square per round. Anyone moving through the fire must succeed at a DC 10 Constitution saving throw to do so without taking (4) 1d8 fire damage.

Fog. The cult's ship magically emits a light fog that provides lightly obscures all creatures more than twenty feet away.

Mast. The mast can be used to take three-quarters cover.

Rigging. The edges of the ship and the mast are awash in tangled rigging which can be climbed with a successful DC 10 Strength (Athletics) check).

Tilting Deck. A character moving on his or her turn must succeed on a DC 10 Dexterity (Acrobatics) check or be thrown off balance, giving others advantage to attacks rolls against them until their next turn. All trained sailors (such as all of the NPCs and any adventurer with the Sailor background) make this check with advantage.

ADJUSTING THE ADVENTURE

Here are recommendations for adjusting this combat encounter. These are not cumulative.

- **Very weak party:** remove two kobolds and one pirate; two enemies die at the end of each round by each other's hands
- **Weak party:** remove two kobolds and one pirate
- **Strong party:** add two kobolds and one pirate
- **Very strong party:** add four kobolds and two pirates

DEVELOPMENTS

Captured cultists, including Ixas, break easily and can be forced to tell their tale. There is a schism in the Cult of the Dragon. One group, to which Ixas belongs, seeks to remain true to the Cult's true purpose of creating a class of undead draconic rulers while another instead seeks the favored *Dragon Masks* that they plan to use to usurp the Cult and lead it in a new direction. Ixas has been chasing rumors and divinations that there was once *Dragon Mask* in this region and coastal town contained a tome told of its last resting place. Given a boat by his master that could glow and shed fog, he concocted the story of the ghost ship hoping to deter investigations by both the authorities and splinter faction cultists. Using the dracolich statue in his quarters, an evil relic of the cult, he feasted on the memories and thoughts of all the captives from the coastal villages hoping to find some clue. The relic however drains itself every time it is used and does not function again until the next phase of the moon. When it is fully charged, a great storm gathers near it until it is used. Thus he used his resources and those of the old guard Cult to search for it, hoping to prevent the splinter faction from their goal.

Ixas also has a number of papers and journals in his quarters, written in Draconic, that detail much of the above. Characters that are members of any of the factions would be interested in getting a hold of some of these papers. There's enough information here to split amongst a few wanting it.

The infernal crew of the *Audacity* are howling mad, driven to rage and barbarity by decades of slavery in the Nine Hells. They seek only to kill every living soul on Faerûn in vengeance, preferably starting with the islanders who sold them to Tiamat's devilish followers. While they are hard to converse with, captured pirates are only too happy to point fingers at the Folk and beg to kill them and wear their skin as a coat.

TREASURE

In Ixas' quarters is the combined wealth of their raids: 500 sp, 500 ep, 75 gp and matching set of Turmish religious idols set with semi-precious stones worth 100 gp each. In addition, there is a man-sized statue of a dracolich, with glowing moonstones for eyes, that radiates both enchantment magic and evil. There is a variety of tradestuffs that they have acquired in bulk that, sadly, end up destroyed in the carnage or sinking with the ships.

Ixas wears a *ring of evasion* that the adventurers may receive as treasure should he be defeated.

CONCLUSION

The immediate threat has ended. Both Doomguide Yovir Glandon and Knight Aleyd Burrall are quite pleased with the success of the adventurers, but they are concerned about news that their backyard has become the battleground for struggle in the Cult of the Dragon. They both promise to warn everyone who will listen about the danger.

With the threat of the raids ended the adventurers must decide what to do with several of the items they recover from the island and the ship.

The Ships. The ships are too badly damaged by the fire to recover. They sink in the shallows near the island.

The Tome and Ixas' Journals. The tome found near the infernal altar and Ixas' journals contain valuable information of the all of the factions desire. The adventurers can easily copy the information and make sure their particular faction is aware of the possible nearness of a *Dragon Mask*.

The Statue. Doomguide Yovir is very curious about the statue and believes that he can use it to repair the damage to Yip's mind. If the adventurers have not yet destroyed it, he asks for it with the promise that it will be destroyed if he is not able to save the man. Otherwise, the adventurers can sell it for 150 gp to an unscrupulous buyer.

The Pirates. The pirates are irredeemable. Any taken captive and turned over to the authorities will be executed.

The Villagers. The Folk that remain refuse to leave the island unless taken prisoner. They are confused by life off the island and any not killed eventually return. The sole exception is Elisande who thrives in Phlan, at first finding a place with the Order of the Silent Shroud, until one night wanderlust takes her and she disappears.

REWARDS

Make sure the players note their rewards on their adventure logsheets. Give your name and DCI number (if applicable) so players can record who ran the session.

EXPERIENCE

Total up all **combat experience** earned for defeated foes, and divide by the number of characters present in the combat. For **non-combat experience**, the rewards listed are per character. Give all characters in the party

non-combat experience awards unless otherwise noted.

COMBAT AWARDS

Name of Foe	XP per Foe
Bandit (pirate)	25
Captain Reeve Sar Testain	700
Commoner	10
Dire wolf	200
Guard	25
Infernal pirate	50
Ixas, Wearer of Purple	450
Kobold	25
Lemure	10
Three crones	50
Ulburto	100
Warsh	450

NON-COMBAT AWARDS

Task or Accomplishment	XP per Character
Rallying the villagers	50
Leaving the villagers in peace	50
Finding information on the <i>Dragon Masks</i>	150

The **minimum** total award for each character participating in this adventure is **450 experience points**.

The **maximum** total award for each character participating in this adventure is **600 experience points**.

TREASURE

The characters receive the following treasure, divided up amongst the party. Characters should attempt to divide treasure evenly whenever possible. Gold piece values listed for sellable gear are calculated at their selling price, not their purchase price.

Consumable magic items should be divided up however the group sees fit. If more than one character is interested in a specific consumable magic item, the DM can determine who gets it randomly should the group be unable to decide.

Permanent magic items are divided up according to a system. See the sidebar if the adventure awards permanent magic items.

TREASURE AWARDS

Item Name	GP Value
Old trade bars on infernal altar	200
Ixas' plunder (500 sp, 500 ep)	55
Turmish religious idols (2)	100 each
Dracolich statue	150

POTION OF HEALING

A description of this item can be found in the basic rules or the *Player's Handbook*.

RING OF EVASION

This intricate thin silver ring is decorated with tiny opalescent stones and glows with a pale radiance (dim light in a 5-foot radius) while in the moonlight. A description of this item can be found in the basic rules or the *Player's Handbook*.

RENOWN

All faction members earn **one renown point** for participating in this adventure.

Order of the Gauntlet, Emerald Enclave, and Lords' Alliance characters earn **one additional renown point** for completing their assignments.

DOWNTIME

Each character receives **ten downtime days** at the conclusion of this adventure.

DM REWARDS

You receive **300 XP** and **ten downtime days** for each session you run of this adventure.

APPENDIX: MONSTER/NPC STATISTICS

BANDIT (PIRATE)

Medium humanoid (any race), any non-lawful alignment

Armor Class 12 (leather armor)

Hit Points 11 (2d8 + 2)

Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
11 (+0)	12 (+1)	12 (+1)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)

Senses passive Perception 10

Languages any one language (usually Common)

Challenge 1/8 (25 XP)

ACTIONS

Scimitar. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 4 (1d6 + 1) slashing damage.

Light Crossbow. *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, range 80 ft./320 ft., one target. *Hit:* 5 (1d8 + 1) piercing damage.

CAPTAIN REEVE SAR TESTAIN (VETERAN)

Medium humanoid (human), lawful evil

Armor Class 17 (splint)

Hit Points 58 (9d8 + 18)

Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
16 (+3)	13 (+1)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)	10 (+0)

Skills Athletics +5, Perception +2

Senses passive Perception 12

Languages any one language (usually Common)

Challenge 3 (700 XP)

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The veteran makes two longsword attacks. If it has a shortsword drawn, it can also make a shortsword attack.

Longsword. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 7 (1d8 + 3) slashing damage, or 8 (1d10 + 3) slashing damage if used with two hands.

Shortsword. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 6 (1d6 + 3) piercing damage.

Heavy Crossbow. *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, range 100/400 ft., one target. *Hit:* 5 (1d10) piercing damage.

COMMONER

Medium humanoid (any race), any alignment

Armor Class 10

Hit Points 4 (1d8)

Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)

Senses passive Perception 10

Languages any one language (usually Common)

Challenge 0 (10 XP)

ACTIONS

Club. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +2 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 2 (1d4) bludgeoning damage.

DIRE WOLF

Large beast, unaligned

Armor Class 14 (natural armor)

Hit Points 37 (5d10 + 10)

Speed 50 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
17 (+3)	15 (+2)	15 (+2)	3 (-4)	12 (+1)	7 (-2)

Skills Perception +3, Stealth +4

Senses passive Perception 13

Languages —

Challenge 1 (200 XP)

Keen Hearing and Smell. The wolf has advantage on Wisdom (Perception) checks that rely on hearing or smell.

Pack Tactics. The wolf has advantage on an attack roll against a creature if at least one of the wolf's allies is within 5 feet of the creature and the ally isn't incapacitated.

ACTIONS

Bite. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 10 (2d6 + 3) piercing damage. If the target is a creature, it must succeed on a DC 13 Strength saving throw or be knocked prone.